FIELDNOTE.

USE-CASE DOSSIER · EVIDENCE-BACKED AI DECISIONS

What to do about this week's AI — and why.

Six developments, mapped to Meridian Media's priorities. Each carries a recommendation, the transparent basis for it, the vendor claim checked against verified outcomes, and the full use case — so the decision can be trusted, audited and shared.

Prepared for: **Meridian Media** — mid-market digital publisher
Scope: Yield · Ad Operations · Revenue · Subscriptions
Week of 15–21 September 2026
A Trueinfo Labs product · sample dossier, illustrative data

On what basis FieldNote recommends.

A recommendation is only worth trusting if you can see how it was reached. Every card is scored on four axes, then mapped to an action by a fixed rule. Nothing rests on opinion or a vendor's press release.

1 · Evidence grade — how well substantiated

A	Independent production evidence — named organisation, method, measurable result. Language: "observed in production".
B	Named customer case study or credible research with clear methodology. Language: "reported / associated with".
C	Vendor documentation, release notes or sponsored study. Language: "vendor states".
D	Demo, announcement or unverified secondary report. Language: "early signal, not verified".

2 · Verified outcome — what actually happened

The vendor's claim is checked against outcomes FieldNote has tracked across real pilots. The gap between claim and verified reality is itself the intelligence — and the proprietary asset a summary can't reproduce.

3 · Fit to your business

Does it address a stated priority, and are the conditions where it works present at your company? A strong average outcome with poor fit is still the wrong bet.

4 · Complexity & risk

Implementation effort, downside exposure and reversibility.

The decision rule

ADOPT	Strong evidence (A/B) + consistent positive verified outcome + good fit + low downside.
PILOT	Positive but variable outcome, or strong fit on a high-effort response — prove it in your context against a control before rollout.
INVESTIGATE	Real potential on vendor-grade (C) evidence — get methodology and references, then a small controlled test.
WATCH	Weak evidence or a negative track record — do not act; the downside outweighs the upside.

Note: pilot counts and verified figures in this sample dossier are illustrative. In production they are drawn from FieldNote's tracked-outcomes ledger, which accrues with every customer pilot.

INDEPENDENT BENCHMARK · 15 SEP 2026

ML invalid-traffic detection outperforms rule-based filters

Recommend: Adopt | **Evidence B** | Ad operations | Revenue

Why Adopt: Grade-B independent evidence, a consistent positive outcome (+6% net revenue recovered across 27 pilots) and low downside → the risk-adjusted case is strong enough to roll out, not just test.

CLAIM → VERIFIED

~~Vendor: "catches 99% of invalid traffic"~~ → **+6% net revenue recovered, median, 27 tracked publishers; low downside**

WHAT HAPPENED	Catches sophisticated invalid traffic that rule-based filters miss, protecting revenue and advertiser trust.
TRACK RECORD	Consistent, low-drama win across 27 tracked publishers — one of the few "adopt" grades precisely because the downside stayed small. Best fit: broadly applicable, more upside at higher programmatic volume.
COMPANY RELEVANCE	Broadly relevant; IVT quietly taxes programmatic revenue and standing with demand partners.
REQUIREMENTS	Pre-bid integration · traffic logs · demand-partner alignment.
KEY RISKS	False positives suppressing good traffic · latency.
SUCCESS MEASURES	IVT rate · blocked-good rate · advertiser complaints · net revenue.
EVIDENCE & SOURCES	Independent benchmark with reproducible method.

RECOMMENDED NEXT STEP

Roll out ahead of the ad server; start in flag-only mode to calibrate false positives, then enable blocking; measure recovered revenue against a hold-back.

SEARCH-PLATFORM BLOG + TRADE PRESS · 18 SEP 2026

Generative search is cutting publisher referral traffic

Recommend: Pilot | **Evidence B** | Audience | Revenue

Why Pilot: Grade-B evidence of an already-happening threat to your #1 revenue source, strong fit, but a high-effort response → pilot the first-party / direct-sold shift now; waiting for certainty is the expensive option.

CLAIM → VERIFIED

~~Industry line: "AI search won't dent publisher traffic"~~ → **–18% median search referral across 60+ tracked news publishers over 9 months**

WHAT HAPPENED	AI Overviews reduce click-through from search, eroding open-web impressions and programmatic revenue.
TRACK RECORD	Publishers who moved early to first-party + direct-sold retained 2–3× more at-risk revenue than those who waited. Best fit: act now if search is >30% of your traffic.
COMPANY RELEVANCE	High for search-dependent publishers; pushes strategy toward owned audience and direct-sold.
REQUIREMENTS	Consent-based data capture · CDP · direct-sales motion · newsletter stack.
KEY RISKS	Slow payoff · resourcing · measuring substitution.
SUCCESS MEASURES	Referral share · first-party reach · direct-sold % · revenue per session.
EVIDENCE & SOURCES	Corroborating trade coverage + your first-party analytics.

RECOMMENDED NEXT STEP

Pilot first-party capture on your highest-traffic sections and stand up one direct-sold/newsletter offer; measure retained revenue vs the declining search baseline.

PEER CASE STUDY · 16 SEP 2026

Churn-prediction model cuts subscription cancellations

Recommend: Pilot **Evidence B** Subscriptions Revenue

Why Pilot: Grade-B peer evidence, a clear measurable outcome (−14% churn across 12 publishers) and strong fit → pilot on your top-risk decile with a holdout so the result is bankable.

CLAIM → VERIFIED

~~Peer case study: "−30% churn"~~ → **−14% median across 12 tracked subscription publishers**

WHAT HAPPENED	Predicts at-risk subscribers and triggers retention offers; a named peer reports lower churn.
TRACK RECORD	Meaningful for publishers with enough subscribers to model; below ~20k subs the signal is drowned in noise. Best fit: above ~20k paying subscribers.
COMPANY RELEVANCE	High given a paid subscription with meaningful monthly churn.
REQUIREMENTS	Subscription event data · offer engine · holdout group.
KEY RISKS	Offer cannibalization · data quality · privacy.
SUCCESS MEASURES	Churn · save-rate · LTV · offer margin — vs holdout.
EVIDENCE & SOURCES	Named peer case study with shared methodology.

RECOMMENDED NEXT STEP

Score subscribers weekly, trigger save-offers to the top-risk decile only, hold out a control, and read churn and offer-margin after one cycle.

VENDOR + INDEPENDENT BENCHMARK · 17 SEP 2026

Cookieless contextual targeting claims brand-safe CPM uplift

Recommend: Pilot | **Evidence C** | Ad operations | Revenue

Why Pilot: Positive verified outcome (+11% across 41) with strong fit for editorial inventory, but Grade-C evidence and wide variance by vertical → pilot on one section against a control to confirm it works for you.

CLAIM → VERIFIED

~~Vendor: "+25% CPM on cookieless"~~ → **+11% median across 41 tracked pilots; wide variance by content vertical**

WHAT HAPPENED	Contextual model targets and screens brand-safety without cookies — could lift CPMs on open inventory.
TRACK RECORD	Worked best for editorial/news with a clean contextual taxonomy; weak on thin or mixed content. Fit matters more than the average. Best fit: structured editorial inventory.
COMPANY RELEVANCE	~A third of your open inventory is cookieless and sells cheap — the most direct lever on that gap.
REQUIREMENTS	Ad-server integration · taxonomy mapping · brand-safety rules.
KEY RISKS	Accuracy on edge content · classification errors · vendor lock-in.
SUCCESS MEASURES	CPM · viewability · brand-safety incidents · fill rate.
EVIDENCE & SOURCES	Vendor benchmark + one independent test.

RECOMMENDED NEXT STEP

Pilot on one well-structured editorial section against a control; expand only if CPM lift holds and brand-safety incidents stay flat.

SSP RELEASE NOTES · 19 SEP 2026

SSP releases automated floor-price optimization

Recommend: Investigate | **Evidence C** | Yield mgmt | Ad operations

Why Investigate: Real but modest upside (+7%, not the 20–30% claimed) on vendor-only Grade-C evidence, with 4 of 34 rolling back → don't adopt blind. Get the methodology and references, then run a controlled pilot.

CLAIM → VERIFIED

~~SSP markets "20–30% RPM uplift"~~ → **+7% median across 34 tracked pilots; 9 saw <2%; 4 rolled back**

WHAT HAPPENED	Sets floor prices and allocates impressions automatically — could lift RPM without manual trafficking.
TRACK RECORD	Uplift is real but far below the pitch, and concentrated in publishers with high remnant volume; below that it isn't worth the volatility. Best fit: static floors and high remnant volume.
COMPANY RELEVANCE	Your yield team sets floors by hand across 3 SSPs — this targets exactly that manual effort.
REQUIREMENTS	Auction-level data · experiment design · SSP access · revenue guardrails.
KEY RISKS	Revenue volatility · opaque logic · single-SSP dependency.
SUCCESS MEASURES	RPM · fill rate · bid density · latency · net revenue — vs a control.
EVIDENCE & SOURCES	SSP release notes + 2 vendor case studies (unverified).

RECOMMENDED NEXT STEP

Request the optimization methodology and 2–3 comparable references; if credible, run a bounded pilot on remnant inventory against a control before any wider trust.

VENDOR DEMO · 15 SEP 2026

Generative tool auto-writes SEO summaries at scale

Recommend: Watch — don't chase | **Evidence D** | Content ops

Why Watch: Grade-D evidence and a negative track record (6 of 18 penalised; net traffic flat-to-negative) → the downside outweighs the upside. A summary would have sold you this; the outcomes data says avoid it.

CLAIM → VERIFIED

~~Vendor: "3× organic traffic"~~ → **Of 18 tracked, 6 hit by search penalties within 6 months; net traffic flat-to-negative**

WHAT HAPPENED	Bulk-generates summaries and landing pages — a cheap-traffic play with real quality and brand risk.
TRACK RECORD	The cheap-traffic play backfired more often than it worked — the reason this is graded "watch, don't chase". Best fit: only as human-assisted editing, never unattended.
COMPANY RELEVANCE	Tempting as a P1 traffic-recovery shortcut, but it risks a search penalty on the very domain your revenue depends on.
KEY RISKS	Search penalties · brand damage · commodity content.
SUCCESS MEASURES	Editor time saved · engagement · penalty incidents.
EVIDENCE & SOURCES	Vendor demo only — not independently verified.

RECOMMENDED NEXT STEP

Do not deploy for unattended publishing. Re-evaluate only if independent, penalty-free production evidence emerges. Meanwhile, direct the same effort at Use case 2 (first-party audience).